

Research Proposal

Research Title:

Does Banning Child Marriage Improve Female Schooling Attainment? Evidence from Bangladesh.

Abstract

This study aims to show the impact of the 2004 policy amendment to the Child Marriage Restraint Act (1929) in Bangladesh on female schooling attainment. The amendment required birth certificates for marriage registration, aiming to strictly enforce the legal marriage age of 18 for females. By analyzing schooling outcomes before and after this policy change, this research will analyze the effectiveness of policy amendment in improving female education. Using World Development Indicator data and DID identification strategy, the study will find the casual relationship of schooling attainment rates and average years of schooling among girls after the policy has changed.

Introduction

Bangladesh has the second highest child marriage rate in the world: 74% of women aged 20-49 were married before age 18 (UNICEF, 2014). Despite the Child Marriage Restraint Act (1929) setting the legal age of marriage at 18 for females and 21 for males, enforcement was historically very weak. The penalties were limited to one month's imprisonment or a fine of up to 1,000

BDT(11.34 CAD) or both (Emory Law School). Any adult or guardian arranging and permitting child marriage could be convicted under the law. Girls could not be sentenced to imprisonment. To be punished, a case had to be registered with a court of law within one year of the marriage (Plan international 2013).

The 2004 amendment to the Birth and Death Registration Act, which made it mandatory for birth certificates for marriage registration, aimed to strengthen compliance with age requirements.

This study seeks to analyze the impact of this amendment on female schooling attainment. Specifically, it examines whether the enforcement of age requirements through birth certificates has led to an increase in average years of school completion rates among girls. The research will be based on data from 1995 to 2015, to capture trends before and after the policy change.

Addressing this issue is crucial for achieving gender equality and sustainable development goals.

The study focuses on the following research question:

“Did the 2004 child marriage policy amendment in Bangladesh increase average years of school rates among females under 18?”

A higher success rate for Child marriage restriction implies that effective application of such policy can be implemented on countries with similar socio-economic conditions.

Literature Review

Previous studies have shown there are religious and economic condition as the determinants of child marriage in Bangladesh. A study by Kamal et al. (2015) using BDHS data showed that over 78.2% of Bangladeshi women were married below the legal age of marriage .

The impact of child marriage on educational attainment has been well-documented. Women who marry before age 18 are less likely to continue their education post-marriage (Hicks 2019). Field and Ambrus (2008) showed that each year of delay in marriage raises female schooling by 0.22 years. This study will focus on a different dataset over a longer period. Hicks and Hicks (2019) showed delay in marriage causes a 0.78-year increase per year of delay in marriage in rural Kenya. However this study will be based on Bangladesh which might show the different effectiveness considering recent social and economic situations. Early marriage negatively impacts educational attainment and economic empowerment of women in Bangladesh (Buchman 2018, Kamal 2016). Legal reforms and enforcement of marriage age laws are critical in reducing child marriages and improving educational outcomes (World Bank 2016).

Methodology

The primary data source for this study will be the World Development Indicator (WDI), which provides information on marriage ages, educational attainment, and socio-economic status. This study will also use Barro-Lee Educational Data-Set to access education level data for the girls in Bangladesh.

This study will use a difference-in-difference (DiD) framework, comparing average age of marriage before versus after the 2004 amendment. The model is specified as follows:

$$\text{Years of Schooling}_{it} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \cdot \text{Post_2004}_t + \beta_2 \cdot \text{Treated}_i + \beta_3 (\text{Post_2004}_t \times \text{Treated}_i) + \gamma \mathbf{X}_{it} + \epsilon_{it}$$

here:

- **Years of Schooling_{it}** : Average years of schooling for individual i at time t .
- **Post_2004_t**: A dummy variable that takes the value 1 if the year t is after 2004 (post-policy period) and 0 otherwise (pre-policy period).
- **Treated_i**: A dummy variable that takes the value of 1 if the individual i belongs to the group affected by the policy and 0 otherwise (for group affected by the policy).
- **Post_2004_t × Treated_i**: An interaction term capturing the DiD effect, representing the differential impact of the policy on the treated group relative to the comparison group after the policy change.
- **X_{it}**: Control variables that may affect educational outcomes, such as socio-economic status.
- **ε_{it}**: The error term.

Analysis

This study will examine if this child marriage ban amendment has an impact on average years of schooling for girls under 18 years of age. The analysis will focus on examining the trends in child marriage rates and female educational attainment before and after the 2004 amendment.

I expect the coefficient for interaction term to be positive and significant, which will indicate that after the rule was implemented, there is a positive impact caused by the policy change.

However, potential challenges in this study include data limitations and endogeneity concerns. So this study will also include additional robustness checks to ensure the validity of the study and addressing the potential endogeneity issue.

References

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